14 December 2025 — The Light That Never Dims, *Parashas Vayigash* and חנוכה

Independent review · read fresh, from the finished HTML only (as delivered, before part-3 corrections) · 1 November 2026

1.Overall Read

A six-section write-up (roughly 1,900 words of body and a five-note *Mareh Mekomos* apparatus) on *Yosef HaTzadik* as the model of success and on the hostages' *menorah* in the Gaza tunnel, joined by the Kiel photograph. The spine is clear and the arc is strong: the survivor who cannot cry (I), the three phases of *Yosef* (II), the tunnel (III), Kiel (IV), the connection to our own candles (V), and the secret (VI). The hard editorial issues are five: (a) the verse the survivor recites does not belong to *Hallel*; (b) the opening and the lead describe the piece in ways its own body does not support; (c) the chronology of the footage is internally impossible; (d) the Kiel apparatus contradicts the body; and (e) the *mareh mekomos* contains confident claims that look invented.

2.What Works

- **The three-phase structure (II).** Light, power, darkness, with the Torah silent in the first two and speaking three times in the third, is the best argument in the piece and is set out in order.
- **The Midrash scene.** Potiphar's fear of sorcery and *Yosef*'s whispered thanks is vivid and well paced.
- **The lesson-for-our-children callout.** A well-used callout: it states

the thesis once, simply.

- **The turn from Kiel to the tunnel (IV–V).** “We do not need only stories from the Holocaust anymore” is the right emotional pivot, and the line about the flame that cannot be extinguished lands.
- **The ending.** Returns to *Yosef*, answers the hard question (“why didn’t they get out?”) with humility.

3.Where It’s Weak or Could Be Sharper

The survivor’s verse. Section I has him recite המלאך הגאל אתי מכל רע and calls it a phrase “we say in הלל.” These words are Yaakov’s blessing of Efraim and Menashe, not part of *Hallel*, and fn 1 concedes as much while calling the survivor’s reading “reinterpretive.” The speaker is saying that every time he recites *Hallel* he thinks of what was done to him. A learned reader sees that the quotation and the claim do not match.

The chronology of the footage. “This was two חנוכות ago, about ten months after October 7. We now know they were shot… around August 2024.” Two years before December 2025 is December 2023, about two months after October 7, not ten; and August 2024 *is* about ten months after. The sentence puts the lighting and the murder at the same moment. Fn 4 gives December 2023 and August 2024 correctly, so the body contradicts its own note.

The lead and the opening. The lead says “not on our usual *sugya* of תפילה,” a reader has no way to know what that series is. The opening says the encounter “transformed my understanding of what חנוכה really means,” yet the survivor has nothing to do with the holiday, and the next section is on *Yosef*. The sentence closing the story (“this encounter gave me a new understanding of what חנוכה is about”) promises a link that the piece never draws. Either draw it (the survivor who cannot cry; the tunnel six who light anyway) or say less.

Kiel: the note contradicts the body. The body says the inscription reads

"Chanukah 1932/1933"; fn 5 gives "Chanukah, 5694" (which is 1933–34), a German original, and a lifespan (1890–1962) that no sentence of the body needs. The fn says the family "fled" in 1933 and that the photograph is "at Yad Vashem" and in the "Posner family collection," and calls it "the eighth night" while the body says "last night… Friday evening." Pick one set of facts. The claim that the Nazi headquarters stood across the street is presented as fact and should be sourced or attributed.

"Three times" in II. "Three times the *Torah* calls *Yosef 'matzliach'*" and then "Three times it says *vayehi Hashem ito*." Fn 2 shows the verses but its third quotation ("*vayehi Hashem es Yosef… vechol asher hu asah Hashem matzliach*") splices two verses together, and the title *ish matzliach* is in only one of the three. Say "three times the word *matzliach*."

The voice. The piece moves between the sefer voice and the speaker's: "I want to begin…," "I once sat together…," "please help me say the truth," "you all know the picture." Acceptable for a *drashah* in first person, but the lead then switches to "This week's drasha" as if it were a series entry. Choose.

Two hard sentences. "I do not know which Hamas terrorist filmed that video, but he did us a great favor" is a bold line; as the speaker's own it works, but it needs the context that it is a rhetorical turn (the hostages' light reaching us), or it can be read as thanking the captor. And "who… were more frum, more ehrlich, more Jewish than all of us put together" is the speaker's praise and should stand as such, without the parenthetical "please help me say the truth" run into the sentence.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Fn 1. Cites *Bereishis* 48:16 and says the phrase "entered the standard *Kriyas Shema al hamitah* in many *siddurim*." True of the verse,

irrelevant to *Hallel*; see above.

Fn 2. The third quotation is a splice (see above). “The [illegible] to receive the title” is true of the phrase, not of the root (compare *Bereishis* 24:21, 24:40).

Fn 3. “ו ה" בראשית רבה פ is ambiguous (chapter 86, section 5, reads “ו, ה" פרשה פ). “The [illegible] develops this as the secret… and [illegible] “traced back to [illegible] read as the editor’s gloss. The body says *baruch Hashem*, the Jewish habit named in the note; a reader of the *Rashi* will want to know what the *Rashi* actually says.

Fn 4. “Footage released publicly in late 2025” but “preserved in IDF and family-released archives” is an unsupported claim; the list of six hostages is incomplete (“among them Hersh Goldberg-Polin and others”);

the “Rafah tunnel” is correct but unsourced.

Fn 5. See above. Also, “widely reproduced… one of the most iconic images of pre-Holocaust European Jewish defiance” is true but promotional; the German in italics, rendered as a quotation of an original, should be flagged as unverified or removed.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- Section headings mix styles: “A Story of Tears,” “The Measure of Success — יוסף הצדיק,” “A Gift From Heaven — The מנורה in the Tunnel.” Pick one device.
- The subhead “What They Did” (III) is followed by a paragraph that is half description, half the speaker’s recollection of the remark; consider a separate subhead for the remark.
- “Hersh Goldberg” in the body, “Hersh Goldberg-Polin” in fn 4; unify.
- Section V’s one-sentence second paragraph (“We will feel it from generation to generation”) could join the first.
- “Reworked from the original דרשה” and “Reworked from a דרשה delivered…” (kicker and colophon) are the same statement twice.
- The colophon wishes “שמחות” but the body’s close does not; a final line in the body would balance it.

6.Bottom Line

> *A moving and well-shaped short drashah whose argument (success is knowing God is with you in the pit) is real Torah and well placed. It needs one mechanical pass for its firm errors (the verse in I, the chronology in III, the 1932/5694 contradiction in IV and V), one framing fix (the lead and the opening), and a hedging pass over an apparatus that states particulars (dates, archives, a German text) which nothing in the body supports. With those done it can stand as a short sefer chapter.*

Produced by an independent editorial pass reading the finished HTML only, without the transcripts. Reviewer brings the perspective of a learned general reader familiar with *Tanakh*, *Rashi* and the standard *siddur*.